

WHAT DAY IS IT?

Depending on where you are located in our country, your daily schedule has been altered for at least the past six weeks. When the virus reached the United States, it didn't take long for schools and churches to close. Most of us have been living a different normal for almost two months, and time has become a construct with fuzzy boundaries. The flexible nature of time has been studied by physicists since Albert Einstein developed his Theory of General Relativity in 1915. His theory is meant to give further understanding to the way gravity impacts time.

A Recent Discovery in Space

In April, scientists discovered more evidence within our galaxy that confirms Einstein's 105-year-old theory. A star, called S2, orbits the supermassive black hole at the center of the Milky Way, but it's the shape and motion of S2 that drew their attention. It circles in an elliptical and forward motion, rotating over time to form a rosette shape around the black hole. For Einstein, the larger the mass of an object, the more it bends the fabric of the space-time continuum and the stronger its effects are on nearby objects. The slower you move through space, the faster you move through time.

General Relativity and Faith

S2 orbits around the black hole much like our faith orbits around God. The more significance God holds in our lives, the more effect it has on our faith, sending us into forward motion. Lately time has been doing weird things: March felt like it would never end, but April seemed to fly by in a blur. Sleep patterns have been disrupted, and each day feels eerily similar to the last. The calendars we use to stay organized break up days and months into equally sized units of time, but what do we do when those units of time don't feel equal anymore? Today's issue reminds us it is good news that the God we worship created time, but when time becomes irrelevant, what impact does that leave on our understanding of God?

TIP FOR THIS ISSUE

It is not necessary to fully grasp Einstein's theory of general relativity, but if your students are into that kind of thing, here is a helpful video for leaders and students about time dilation: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=yuD34tEpRFw>.

You can also draw on students' prior experience with time dilation if they have ever been to camp or on a mission trip. Often, those days are so packed with experiences and activities that a 24-hour period can feel much, much longer than days spent at home.



TEACHER BIBLE PREP



TIME IS A CONSTRUCT

Question of the Day: What has your daily life looked like since quarantine began?

Purpose: To discover God's unchanging nature when everything else is changing.

Cultural Connection: Quarantine Schedules

Topic: Time

A SEASON FOR EVERYTHING

Ecclesiastes 3:1-8

There's a season for everything and a time for every matter under the heavens. —Ecclesiastes 3:1

Commentary:

The Book of Ecclesiastes was written to the Israelites during a time of great prosperity. Everything was going their way, and the author wanted to challenge the idea that material things equaled success and eternal happiness. He wrote several musings about the world as he saw it, including this observation about time. Calendars and time-keeping measures as we know them in our modern lives did not exist during the time of the Israelites.

Instead, they measured time by seasons, viewing the natural world as a sort of timekeeper. In our modern linear understanding of time, everything is moving in one direction towards one certain end; but, in a seasonal understanding of time, there's a repetition built into the rhythm of the universe. Fall is a time for harvest, winter brings about death, new life emerges in spring, and summer is a season to feast. It begs the question: What season are we in now?

Questions to think about:

- ▶ What season are you experiencing right now?
- ▶ How do you mark time in your daily life?
- ▶ Are there defining moments in your personal history that serve as transitional moments from one season to the next?

IT'S A MARATHON, NOT A SPRINT

Philippians 3:7-16

Brothers and sisters . . . I do this one thing: I forget about the things behind me and reach out for the things ahead of me. The goal I pursue is the prize of God's upward call in Christ Jesus. —Philippians 3:13-14



Commentary:

Paul was big on “running” metaphors in his letters. Several times he compares the life of a Christian to that of a marathon runner. Both need endurance; neither come with instant or quickly attained gratification; and struggle is part of the reality. At the end of our spiritual race, there isn't a medal and podium but instead complete fellowship with Christ, which is the whole reason why we signed up for the endeavor in the first place.

Our current culture demands instant rewards. Companies constantly are one-upping themselves with two-day shipping, one-day shipping, and now same-day delivery or pick up. Teachers are pushed to post grades online as quickly as possible. The art of waiting has fallen to the wayside, leaving us disoriented when solutions don't solve problems in less than 48 hours. The kingdom of God is about the long game, the marathon. Paul reminds us the spiritual life is not a sprint.

Questions to think about:

- ▶ How has your life slowed down recently?
- ▶ What things are demanding but not deserving of your immediate time and energy?

MARKERS OF TIME

Leviticus 23:37-38

These are the LORD's appointed times that you will proclaim as holy occasions, offering food gifts to the LORD: entirely burned offerings, grain offerings, communal sacrifices, and drink offerings—each on its proper day. —Leviticus 23:37

TEACHER BIBLE PREP



Our calendars break up days and months into equally sized units of time, but what do we do when those units of time don't feel equal anymore?

Commentary:

After fleeing from Pharaoh and the Egyptian army, the Hebrew people finally have a moment to stop and learn what it means to be covenant people of God. In the Book of Leviticus, God gives Moses all the details on how the Israelites should live in the world and worship the holy God. One of those forms of worship concerns sacred festivals, including Passover, the Festival of Weeks, and the Festival of Booths. By observing these rituals, God's people made a habit of remembering their history and marking the passage of time.

There are several rituals within the Christian church that we use for the same purpose. Confirmation, Senior Sundays, All Saints Day, Children's Sabbath, and the sacraments of Communion and baptism all tell the story of how God continually has shown up for us and for our ancestors. A lot of our secular and religious rituals have been put on hold right now out of concern and for the safety of our fellow neighbors. The good news is God hasn't stopped celebrating and telling our story!

Questions to think about:

- ▶ What rituals hold significance in your life?
- ▶ Why are rituals an important part of any culture?

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DEVOTION: TIME MARCHES ON

Looking at a 2020 calendar, notice how each of the boxes for individual days are even, with each day offering 24 hours, and each month displaying its allotted amount of days. You may even see events scheduled that have been canceled or rescheduled at this point; or, maybe this is the first time you've been able to find today's date without searching.

Use a blank piece of paper and redraw the months of March, April, and May, resizing the days according to the way you have experienced the passing of time. This may mean the last two weeks of March have much larger boxes compared to April, and the boxes may begin to become more equal in size the closer you get to May. However you have experienced time, draw a visual that more accurately represents the reality you have been living.

Now, retrieve a candle and light it as you spend some time in reflection and prayer:

"Almighty God, you are the creator of time and are not bound by our human understanding of creation. Thank you for giving us ways to measure and track our daily routines. Stir within me a deeper trust in your ever-present grace and truth. Amen."

NEXT WEEK: As it becomes clear that for most teens the idea of traditional graduation ceremonies is at best a distant hope, some schools are turning to alternative plans. Next week in LINC we'll talk about some new versions of ways to honor seniors as well as how to continue processing this unusual moment in time.

LINC: Living in Christ is an official resource of The United Methodist Church approved by Discipleship Ministries and published by Youth Ministry Partners and Cokesbury: The United Methodist Publishing House, 2222 Rosa L. Parks Blvd., Nashville, TN 37228-1306.

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Available by e-mail subscription by calling toll free: 800-672-1789. Also available for download from <https://www.cokesbury.com/linc#>.

Writer: Audrua Malvaez

Editor: Kevin Alton

Production Editor: Pam Shepherd

Template Designer: Micah Kandros

THE TIMES, THEY ARE A' CHANGING

Getting Ready: Youth will need their copies of Youth Page 6, pens or pencils, and Bibles.

Leader Note: This lesson is designed for groups who continue to meet digitally. Several options may be modified for use in person if your church has resumed meeting while still practicing social-distancing measures.

Before the Session:

- Email a copy of Youth Page 6 to students.
- Gather a timer, paper, markers or MS Paint software, and objects that represent a ritual such as graduation, confirmation, or Advent. Display near your device screen.
- Plan for a way to share videos and set up a video-conferencing software that allows participants to change their names.
- Plan to share the Scripture readings on screen.

OPEN

Homebound Scavenger Hunt (15 minutes)

As students log on, ask them to tell about their previous week: What did they accomplish? How are they procrastinating? Once everyone has gathered, introduce the opening scavenger hunt. Explain that students will have one minute to find an item you call out (from the list below) and return to the screen. Anyone returning with the item within the time limit receives a point; if teens return outside the time limit, no points are awarded. Make sure the timer can be heard clearly, then call out an item:

- | | |
|-----------------------------|--------------------------------------|
| • a pet | • school supplies |
| • something to use outdoors | • kitchen utensil |
| • headphones | • hair products |
| • something you sleep with | • toilet paper |
| • Chapstick | • source of light (not a cell phone) |

Once the game has run its course, talk about how it felt to play with a time limit. Did teens think there was enough time? Was there too much time for some objects and not enough time to find others? Introduce today's discussion topic by summarizing the article on Page 1, then ask and talk about the following:

- ▶ What has been your biggest struggle in adapting to daily life these last few weeks?
- ▶ Have you noticed anything different about how time feels since quarantine began?

EXPLORE

Talk Topic 1: Time Is Relative (15 minutes)

Middle School Option

Ask teens to travel back in time to kindergarten days and tell what they learned about the four seasons. Compare what they learned in school to how they experience seasons now as a teenager. Say: "Our ancestors used the seasons to tell time. There was a routine to each year, timed by the harvest and the rains. The author of Ecclesiastes studied seasons and the human habits formed around them."

Show Ecclesiastes 3:1-8 on the screen and call on a volunteer to read aloud the passage. Ask:

- ▶ Have you experienced any of the times in life the author mentions in the Scripture?
- ▶ Which times are your favorite?

Prompt students to access a drawing app or grab paper and markers. Invite them to draw a picture of their favorite season of the year and on it list any times from the Scripture passage that might occur in their chosen season. If time allows, call on teens to show and talk about their drawings.

High School Option

Begin the conversation by asking students to tell from memory how many clocks they have in their house. Ask them to submit answers using the chat feature, then send them off to actually count the clocks. When teens return, compare results to the initial estimate. Was anyone surprised? Ask students to pull up on screen or open their Bibles to Ecclesiastes 3 and call on a volunteer to read aloud verses 1-8. Ask and talk about the following questions:

- ▶ We mark time by passing minutes, hours, and days. How does the teacher in Ecclesiastes measure time?
- ▶ Have you ever traveled somewhere that has a different climate from the one you left? What was that like?
- ▶ What season of life do you think you may be in right now?



THE TIMES, THEY ARE A' CHANGING



Talk Topic 2: Running the Race (15 minutes)

Combined Middle School and High School Option

Of the many things disrupted by the coronavirus pandemic, sporting events were among the first casualties. Invite students to look up a video of their favorite sports memory (if available) and share the video with the group. As they share, ask them to tell why this particular moment in sports is a favorite: Did they participate in the event? Was it something they waited a long time to witness?

After volunteers have shared, introduce the Scripture passage by saying something like: “Having grown up in Roman culture, Paul was familiar with athletic endeavors. In his letters, he frequently used running as a metaphor for Christian living.” Read aloud Philippians 3:7-16 making sure everyone can follow along. Ask:

- ▶ In verse 13, Paul says he forgets what’s behind him and looks ahead. Is this attitude helpful for our faith? Why or why not?
- ▶ What is the difference between a marathon and a sprint? Which one do you think Paul would use to describe faith?

BONUS SMALL GROUP DISCUSSION

The final two verses of Philippians 3:7-16 discuss spiritual maturity. It’s important to note that in times of crisis, regression is a perfectly normal response. Some students may be struggling and feel like they’ve fallen behind in some way. On the screen or a piece of chart paper, work with teens to draw a Spectrum of Spiritual Maturity while identifying and labeling some of the various points on the line.

Talk Topic 3: Rituals as Markers (15 minutes)

Middle School Option

Pull up on screen the definition of a ritual (or on Youth Page 6) and call on a volunteer to read it aloud. Ask students to name different

rituals they have participated in or witnessed, including Advent, confirmation, graduations, baptism renewal, Passover, and All Saints Day. Read aloud Leviticus 23:37-38, then say, “In Chapter 23, God instructs the Israelites to remember the ways God has been there for them.” Then ask, “How do our Christian rituals remind us of God’s presence in our lives today?”

After some discussion say: “Like the Exodus in Bible times, this pandemic is a monumental occasion. Throughout history, humans have made time capsules to remember what life was like during major historic events.” Using Youth Page 6, invite students to draw or list items they would put in a time capsule for future generations. When everyone has finished, call on volunteers to show their time capsule drawings or call out the listed items.

High School Option

If possible, show your objects representing rituals. Then choose an object and begin discussion by telling the story behind the ritual or rite it represents. Afterward, allow students a few minutes to look through their house for an object representing a ritual in which they or a family member participated. When everyone returns, conduct a time of show and tell, then ask for a volunteer to read aloud Leviticus 23:37-38.

Using the commentary in Teacher Bible Prep, explain the context of chapter 23. Say: “The festivals of Passover, Weeks, and Booths came with rituals that recounted the story of God’s relationship with the Israelites. These rituals were meant to be observed in addition to regular worship.” Ask:

- ▶ What church rituals do we observe, in addition to regular worship, that tell the story of God’s relationship with us?
- ▶ In the season of Advent, we mark time by lighting a candle each week. What other ways do we mark time in the church?
- ▶ Are there rituals you have missed due to quarantine? How does it feel to miss those times of celebration?

TAKE AWAY

Pray: “Holy God, our time feels strange right now, but we know You are unchanging. In this season of confusion and the unknown, we want to feel your presence. Fill us with your Spirit so that we might become agents of love and peace to those we encounter. Amen.”

WORKING IT OUT

TIME CAPSULE



Ritual—a ceremony that is always performed in the same way, in order to mark an important religious or social occasion rite

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In the Bible: Readings for the Week

MONDAY: Read Hebrews 13:7-8.

Jesus Christ is the same!

TUESDAY: Read Matthew 24:35-36.

God knows what is coming next.

WEDNESDAY: Read Psalm 42:1-3.

What does it feel like to crave God's presence?

THURSDAY: Read Ecclesiastes 3:13-15.

Nothing is new to God!

FRIDAY: Read Jeremiah 29:10-14.

God will bring it all together again.

SATURDAY: Read 1 Corinthians 9:24-27.

Run with perseverance.

Inherit the Mirth



WHAT'S TRENDING?

If clocks and calendars have lost their meaning, what are you using to keep track of the hours and days? Tweet or post your response with the hashtag #quittingtime on Twitter to @YMPartners or on facebook.com/youthministypartners